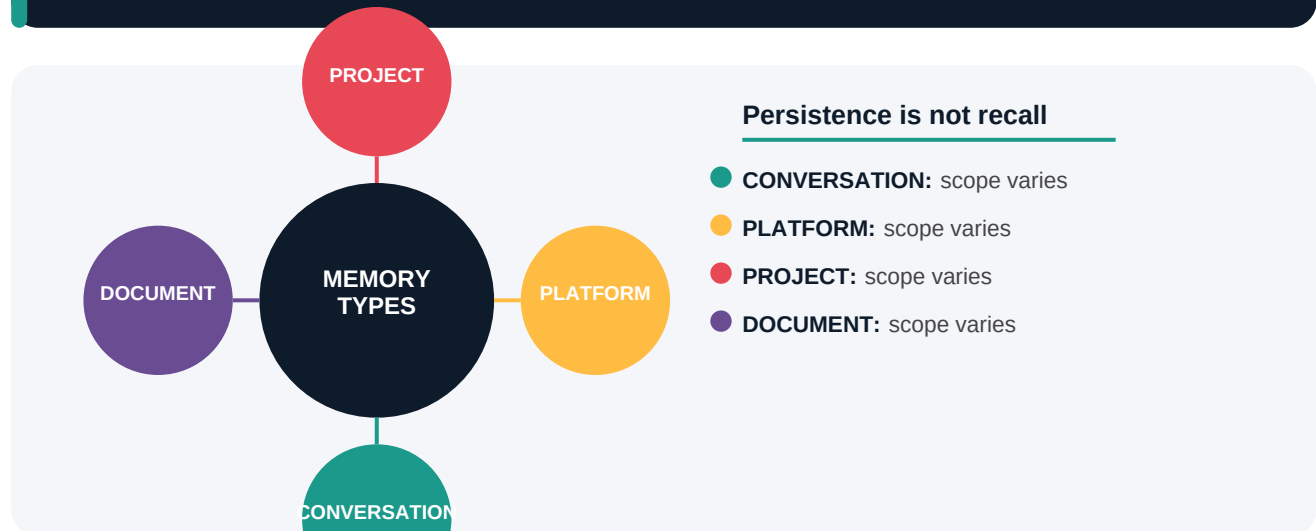


The Memory Problem (and How to Work Around It)



WHY AI DOESN'T RELIABLY REMEMBER YOU Unless a platform explicitly supplies relevant saved context, project knowledge, searchable history, or connected sources, every time you start a new conversation with an AI tool, you are meeting a stranger who happens to be very knowledgeable. They do not reliably know your name, your job, your preferences, your previous conversations, or anything about your situation.

The practical effect is that you should spend time re-establishing important context unless you have confirmed which persistence feature is active and what it can access.

Some platforms have begun introducing memory features, where AI can retain facts between conversations. These features are useful but imperfect, and their availability and reliability vary. This chapter covers the memory problem and its most practical workarounds.



THE FOUR TYPES OF "MEMORY" IN CURRENT AI TOOLS

IN-CONVERSATION MEMORY (ALWAYS AVAILABLE) Within a single conversation, AI remembers everything that has been said. You can refer to "the document we discussed" or "your earlier suggestion" and AI will understand. This is reliable and consistent.

PLATFORM MEMORY FEATURES (VARIABLE) Some platforms offer features that carry specific facts across conversations, things you told AI about yourself, preferences you established, key information you asked it to remember. These vary in scope and reliability.

PRODUCT NOTE (VERIFIED SEPTEMBER 2026): ChatGPT offers saved memory and project memory, with availability and settings varying by plan and workspace. Claude offers profile preferences, project instructions, project knowledge, and where enabled search across previous chats. These are different mechanisms, not a guarantee that an AI remembers everything. Check the current documentation and verify what context a response actually used.

Volatility: HIGH, See Appendix E.

PROJECT MEMORY (THE MOST RELIABLE APPROACH) Working within a Project creates a persistent context that AI carries across all conversations in that project. This is currently the most robust workaround for the memory problem for regular, recurring work.

DOCUMENT MEMORY (THE UNIVERSAL WORKAROUND) A context document you paste in at the start of any conversation. Reliable across all platforms, requires no platform feature, and completely under your control.

BUILDING A CONTEXT DOCUMENT A context document is a brief, structured summary of what AI needs to know about you and the work it will help with. It is the universal workaround for the memory problem.

Here is a template:

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CONTEXT DOCUMENT, [Your name / role] Last updated: [Date]

About me: [2-3 sentences: role, sector, organisation type]

Current work context: [What I'm working on, any ongoing projects, key relationships]

My communication preferences: [Tone, format, UK/US spelling, things I never want in output]

Key constraints: [Anything AI must not say, recommend, or assume]

My standard audience: [Who reads what I produce]

Things I always want AI to do: [Default behaviours, verification flags, format defaults, etc.]

A well-written context document takes twenty minutes to produce once and can be pasted into any AI conversation in seconds. It is more reliable than any platform feature and works across all tools.

A FILLED-IN CONTEXT DOCUMENT Consider Priya, a secondary-school teacher preparing differentiated materials. Her context document might begin:

CONTEXT DOCUMENT, Priya, Year 8 science teacher Last updated: September 2026

I teach mixed-ability Year 8 classes in England. Materials must use plain language, support different reading levels, and align with the current specification I provide. Never invent curriculum requirements or present generated material as ready for students without teacher review. Flag scientific claims,

safety issues, and assumptions.

When I ask for differentiated material, give me a core version and two accessible variations. Keep the learning objective unchanged.



PART III - BUILD AN AI ENVIRONMENT

The document does not make AI responsible for the lesson. It gives AI a stable starting point and tells Priya what to check. She still supplies the current specification and reviews anything pupils will see, but she no longer has to repeat the class context and safety expectations in every session.

MEMORY THAT MATTERS AND MEMORY THAT DOESN'T Not everything needs to be remembered. The investment in persistent context should be proportional to how often you'll need it.

WORTH PERSISTING: Your role, audience, and communication style Recurring project context Key constraints that always apply Your quality standards and preferences

NOT WORTH PERSISTING: One-off tasks Information that changes frequently Details specific to a single conversation

The test: if you would type this information again in your next AI session, persist it. If it's specific to today's task and you won't need it tomorrow, don't bother.

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